the former, according to a 2024 survey by the Internet and Mobile Association of India, and 18 per cent reported being stalked by someone they met on a dating app. Dating apps also became a platform for cybercrime—according to the National Crime Records Bureau, cybercrimes through dating apps rose by 28 per cent from 2021 to 2023. So did financial fraud—with romance costing Indian users an estimated Rs 150 crore in 2023 alone.

All this has led to Indian daters taking a break from dating. Dating app Bumble's survey found 40 per cent of Indian daters doing so in 2023. According to the latest data available on data aggregating site Similarweb, six out of eight major dating apps in India also saw a drop in monthly active users (MAUs) on Android between October 2022 and September 2023. Tinder, which has one of the largest pools of daters on mobile, saw its daily active users (DAUs) and MAUs decline by 20 per cent in India between October 2022 and September 2023.

WOOING BACK THE DATERS

To bring them back, dating apps are going into reset mode. A few have introduced new features for safety, profile-matching; some are even hosting offline meet-ups. Dating app Bumble, for instance, now offers 'dating intentions profile badges'. These allow users to express what they are looking for in their dating journey. They can select two out of the four dating intentions on offer—'casual dating', 'intimacy without commitment', 'life partner' and 'ethical non-monogamy'. "This year," says Lucille McCart, director of corporate communications, Bumble Inc, "we introduced Opening Moves, a post-match question women can set for their matches to respond to within 24 hours—giving women agency and freedom in how the first move is made." Another app, OkCupid, is going the same way. "OkCupid is the only dating app in the world that matches people on what matters to them through in-app questions that have been answered more than 10 billion times since we launched. These questions are about dating and relationships, but also everything that is important to Gen Z and millennial daters, like climate change and reproductive rights," says Michael Kaye, director of brand marketing & communications.

WHAT APPS ARE DOING TO WOO THEM BACK

MATCHING EXPECTATIONS: Some apps now allow users to **display their intentions**—casual, serious, marriage—straight up on their profile to ensure the right two people match

BACK TO HUMAN MATCHMAKING: QuackQuack, which has about 33 million users in India, has introduced the human matchmaker model this year, which will handhold users through the entire process, from creating a profile to initiating conversation

OFFLINE EXPERIENCES: Once a virtual-only app, Aisle has now begun offline meeting feature Aisle Experiences

AI FOR SAFETY: Some features help prioritise the most severe safety reports and shorten response time. AI is also used to identify potential violations of community guidelines and delete spam, scam and fake profiles before people see them

NICHE DATING: Some apps have ventured into **highly specialised dating** by tapping into interest- or community-based dating. So, there's Gleeden (only for married people), Raya (an invite-only app), Turn up (for music enthusiasts), Jalebi (for Gen Z users), Gluten-free Singles and Neetho (only for Telegus)

Other apps are pivoting back to a more traditional and customised approach towards matchmaking. QuackQuack, which has about 33 million users in India, has introduced the human matchmaker model this year, where dating experts handhold the users through the entire process, from creating a profile to initiating conversations. Similarly, Aisle has begun Aisle Experiences, an offline meetings feature. "The core of the event was to bring together people based on a common interest and let them connect in a safe environment," says Nabila Tazyeen, head of content and communications. "We were overbooked for the event, and the in-event feedback has been extremely encouraging. By the end of the evening, approximately 80 per cent of attending Aisle members had asked each other out for a date the following week. This happened because the event was curated with like-minded individuals and organic interactions were high. In fact, most of them continued to hang out after the event and went on to attend an after-party." Tazyeen believes that the way love works in India is quite different from other parts of the world and Aisle offers a middle path between casual dating and traditional matrimony services. "Aspects of family, culture and language are different in the western concept of dating. We connect Indian singles who are in search of meaningful relationships—dating with a specific goal of finding a long-term partner," she says.

AI TO THE RESCUE

Meeting the right person is not the only thing the Indian dater worries about; they are equally concerned about meeting the wrong one. Anirudh Kapadia, 31, an HR executive based in Noida, had